

Price Watch

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Killer Rigs

Looking for a PC configuration to suit your needs? Chose from budget, mid range, high-end and other builds

Mini PCs

In the age of miniaturisation of tech gadgets, the diminutively tiny, space-saving desktop PCs are back in fashion

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There are several good reasons to consider buying a small form factor PC – in other words, a mini PC – to replace your old, dusty desktop computer. No one has the space in their homes to accommodate full tower cabinets and traditional desktop PCs anymore, especially if you're trying to upgrade your 5-6 year old PC – why invite more dust unnecessarily? Most small form factor PCs sold in the market have laptop components when it comes to their processor, graphics card, RAM and hard drive. This isn't great news for gaming enthusiasts or people placing huge demands on their PCs, but it's great for one simple reason – power saving. Laptop components are designed to operate at low power and generally utilise power efficiently, which translates into significant cuts on your electricity bill. Mini PCs are perennial favourites among those trying to set up an HTPC, with a central media server to access through all your smart devices.

If you have to buy mini PCs off the shelf, here are a few suggestions. ZOTAC is leading the charge with its mini PCs in India, and easily has the widest variety (with varying configurations and price ranges) to pick and choose from. Not just configurations, they have products in different shapes and sizes too – from rectangular boxes to spheres. To buy the best performing mini PC in the market, go with the ZOTAC EI750 (Plus) which comes with an Intel Core i7 chip, oodles of RAM,

a large-spaced hard drive and onboard Intel HD Iris Pro 5200 graphics card. Watching HD movies and performing day-to-day activities such as surfing the web and working on productivity sheets should work just fine on it. The EN760 Plus is another knight in shining armour from ZOTAC's stables, equipped with NVIDIA GeForce 860M graphics chip, which should provide some much-needed relief to gaming enthusiasts. Gigabyte's BRIX PC is a competing product that challenges ZOTAC's supremacy, offering much of the same flagship features and a higher-priced SSD variant which should really speed things up considerably in terms of overall end-user experience.

Enough of the high-end mini PCs, let's check out the other extreme – the budget segment. The Intel NUC Kit is a great option within the 10k-20k price segments. The cheapest option running on a Celeron dual-core chip with Windows 8.1 OS and three years warranty is available for purchase on e-commerce websites in India. These tiny PC boxes have standard IO ports, not to mention wireless connectivity options as well. If you want to get your hands dirty, I highly recommend

popping out the standard hard drive from these tiny boxes and replacing it with an SSD – whichever fits your budget. Just the speed bump you'll get will make the experience worth it. Hooking up a NAS or USB 3.0 enabled external hard drive directly to your SSD-enabled mini PC (running either on Windows or XBMC) to serve content onto your HDTV, smartphone, tablet or laptop is a liberating experience to feed our evolving content consumption needs, believe you me. As to where to buy these products from, online is clearly the way to hunt for deals (since most tech-savvy brick-and-mortar computer peripheral stores also sell on e-commerce platforms these days).

In the next month or so, I'll be dismantling my existing mini "media center" PC set-up to try and miniaturise the PC hub even more. How exactly? Let's just say the recently announced Intel Thumb PCs at CES 2015 are going to fall into my lap pretty soon. Can you imagine? A fully functional x86 computer not bigger than the size of a Chromecast. Soon enough I'll let you guys know how that upgrade comes along in the coming months. Until then, stay tuned. 

